



Draft National Urbanization Policy

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1. Foreword

Urbanization of Bangladesh is one of the most significant social and economic transformations of the 21st century. As the country continues to experience rapid urban growth, with millions of people migrating from rural areas to cities in search of better opportunities, the need for a coherent and sustainable urbanization policy has never been more urgent. Urban areas now represent the engine of economic growth, cultural exchange, and innovation, but they also face substantial challenges such as overcrowding, environmental degradation, inadequate infrastructure, social inequality etc.

In response to these challenges, the **National Urbanization Policy**—a comprehensive framework aimed at guiding the country's urbanization toward a more inclusive, sustainable, and resilient future. This policy is grounded in the belief that urbanization should benefit all citizens, regardless of their socio-economic status, by fostering cities that are environmentally responsible, economically vibrant, and socially inclusive. Recognizing that factors such as employment opportunities, living conditions, disaster resilience, and access to services contribute to migration, this policy also emphasizes addressing these challenges to ensure balanced development and improved quality of life across regions.

The **National Urbanization Policy** outlines key strategies to address the multifaceted issues of urban growth, including the provision of affordable housing, the development of smart infrastructure, environmental conservation, the promotion of local governance, and the empowerment of communities. At its core, this policy seeks to create cities that are not only centers of economic activity but also places where people can live dignified lives, with access to basic services, health, education, and employment opportunities.

As Bangladesh moves toward becoming a middle-income country, urbanization will continue to be a defining force in its development trajectory. By adopting this policy, we aim to ensure that our cities are prepared to meet the demands of the future while protecting the rights and well-being of all citizens. This is not only a policy document—it is a vision for the cities of tomorrow, built on the values of sustainability, inclusivity, and resilience.

2. Introduction

Urbanization is a pivotal force shaping the socio-economic landscape of Bangladesh. Over the past few decades, rapid urbanization has been driven by population growth, rural-to-urban migration, and expanding economic opportunities. Cities like Dhaka, Chattogram, Khulna, and Rajshahi have become centers of economic activity, fostering industrial growth and contributing significantly to the national GDP. However, this urban transformation has also introduced complex challenges, highlighting the need for a structured approach to urban planning and development.

One of the most pressing issues is the concentration of population and resources in a few major cities, particularly Dhaka and Chattogram. This over-centralization has led to overburdened infrastructure, severe traffic congestion, housing shortages, and inadequate public services. Furthermore, rapid urban expansion has often occurred without adequate planning, resulting in

urban sprawl, encroachment on agricultural and flood-prone lands, and the proliferation of informal settlements. These factors collectively undermine the livability and resilience of urban areas, creating disparities in access to basic services and economic opportunities.

Environmental degradation is another critical concern associated with unplanned urbanization. The depletion of green spaces, air and water pollution, and inefficient waste management have escalated public health risks in cities. Moreover, Bangladesh's vulnerability to climate change and natural disasters exacerbates the challenges faced by urban areas. Flooding, cyclones, and rising sea levels threaten the sustainability of coastal and low-lying urban regions, making it imperative to integrate climate adaptation and disaster risk management into urban development.

Despite these challenges, urbanization offers immense opportunities for economic growth, innovation, and improved quality of life. With over one-third of the population residing in urban areas, cities serve as engines of economic development and innovation. Harnessing this potential requires a comprehensive and forward-looking urbanization policy that addresses current challenges while promoting sustainable and inclusive growth.

3. Vision

"To foster a well-planned, inclusive, and sustainable urbanization process that drives national socio-economic development, strengthens governance, reduces disparities, ensures environmental resilience, and harmonizes urban and rural development for a balanced and prosperous nation."

4. Mission

- i. Guide the urbanization process to support national socio-economic goals.
- ii. Enhance urban governance frameworks for efficient decision-making.
- iii. Reduce regional disparities by fostering equitable economic and social opportunities.
- iv. Promote environmental sustainability and disaster resilience in urban areas.
- v. Strengthen urban-rural linkages for balanced national development.

5. Strategic Policy Directions

5.1 Governance

- Promote Participatory Planning: Encourage community involvement in planning processes.
- Integrate Disaster Preparedness: Incorporate social and disaster management practices in urban governance.

5.2 Housing and Livable Cities

- Enhancements to ensure basic services reach all areas. (Rwanda's Approach)
- Efforts to enhance living conditions in unregulated areas. (Rwanda's Approach)
- Initiatives to provide cost-effective housing for low-income groups.

5.3 Sustainable Development

- **Promote Green Building and Resource-Efficient Cities:**
Mandate energy efficiency in new constructions and provide **incentives** for retrofitting older buildings with energy-saving technologies (Malaysia NUP), Foster compact urban development with integrated green public spaces, urban forests, and biodiversity corridors to minimize material footprint.
- **Accelerate Renewable Energy Adoption:**
 - Subsidize solar panel installations and expand renewable energy zones in urban and rural areas.
 - Establish microgrids for off-grid communities and mandate energy-efficient appliances in urban households.
- **Advance Green Urban Mobility and Air Quality:**
Invest in low-emission public transportation systems like metro rail, monitor urban air quality, enforce stricter emission standards, and promote afforestation to improve air quality.

5.4 Urban Sprawl

- **Legal Provisions for Smart Growth:**
 - Introduce zoning regulations to control unplanned urban expansion.
- **Integrated Land Use:** Integrate residential, commercial, and recreational spaces to reduce commute times and resource strain. *(Aligned with SDG 11.3.1 Efficient land use).*
- Improve transport infrastructures to enhance connectivity.
- Emphasize sustainable land use by ensuring public open spaces.

5.5 Economic Growth

- **Support Economic Clusters:** Establish industrial hubs outside major cities to reduce migration pressure and promote regional growth (Malaysia's NUP).
- **Encourage Green Economy Practices:** Develop eco-industrial parks and circular economy models to create green jobs and reduce emissions (Malaysia's NUP).
- **Promote special economic zone:** Promote special economic zones to enhance trade efficiency, attract foreign investment, and boost economic growth through seamless global connectivity.

5.6 Universally Accessible Public Space

- **Women-Friendly Urban Spaces:**
 - Design safe, accessible public spaces, transport systems, and housing for women.
- **Economic Empowerment:**
 - Facilitate women's participation in urban governance and employment.

- **Social Infrastructure:** Develop and distribute childcare centers and healthcare facilities across regions to support working women. *(Aligned with SDG 5.5.1 – Women in leadership positions and SDG 11.7.1 – Access to public spaces by gender.)*

5.7 Infrastructure and Mobility

- Promote bike-friendly and pedestrian-friendly urban layouts (Malaysia NUP).
- Expand public transport systems with integrated networks for better connectivity (China NUP).
- Improve water, sanitation, and waste management infrastructure (aligned with SDG 9.1.1) (Rwanda NUP).

5.8 Disaster Management

- Develop flood defense systems & early warning system (China NUP).
- Strengthen climate adaption strategies (Green Infrastructure Development: vertical greenery, wetland restoration, Climate-Resilient Housing, Water Resource Management: Rainwater harvesting, smart irrigation) by providing micro-credits. (Rwanda NUP).
- Improve emergency shelter & healthcare facilities. (Malaysia NUP).

5.9 Cultural Preservation

- **Protect Heritage Buildings:**
 - Retrofit and conserve heritage sites to balance cultural preservation with urban development (Malaysia NUP).
- **Incorporate Local Identity:**
 - Promote region-specific urban planning models that reflect local culture and traditions.
- **Community Engagement:**
 - Involve local communities in planning to protect historical significance while modernizing infrastructure. *(Aligned with SDG 11.4.1 – Expenditure on cultural heritage preservation.)*

5.10 Environmental Policies

- Expand urban green spaces: Greenbelt (aligned with SDG 11.7.1) (Malaysia NUP).
- Implement 3R (Reduce, Reuse, Recycle) waste management campaigns (Rwanda NUP).

5.11 Data and Technology

- **Smart Data Collection:**
 - Use Geographic Information Systems (GIS) for tracking infrastructure needs, disaster risks, and urban growth patterns (Rwanda).
- **Integrated Urban Databases:**
 - Develop platforms for real-time urban data to aid decision-making.
- **Participatory Digital Platforms:**

- Engage citizens in planning through online platforms for feedback and governance (aligned with SDG 11.3.2) (Malaysia NUP).

5.12 Waste Management

- **Promote 3R (Reduce, Reuse, Recycle) Programs:**
 - Educate urban communities on waste reduction and recycling practices. (Malaysia NUP).
- **Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs):**
 - Establish partnerships to improve solid waste collection and recycling systems (Rwanda's approach).
- **Integrated Waste Systems:**
 - Develop eco-industrial parks and centralized waste-to-energy facilities to manage urban waste (aligned with SDG 12.5.1).

5.13 Urban Agriculture

- **Urban Farms and Community Gardens:**
 - Encourage small-scale **urban agriculture** on vacant lots.
 - Grow drought-resistant plants such as chili, tomato, spinach, and herbs.
 - Greywater recycling: Reuse lightly used household water (e.g., from washing vegetables or bathing) for irrigation purposes after basic filtration.
- **Green Supply Chains:**
 - Promote local food cooperatives to link peri-urban farmers with urban consumers.
- **Education and Awareness:**
 - Teach communities about urban farming benefits to support **food security** and sustainability. *(Aligned with SDG 2.4.1 – Sustainable food production.)*

5.14 Youth Empowerment

- **Skill Development Programs:**
 - Create training initiatives to engage youth in urban construction, technology, and green jobs (Malaysia).
- **Youth-Friendly Urban Spaces:**
 - Develop safe, accessible parks, sports complexes, and community centers for youth.
- **Urban Governance Participation:**
 - Involve youth in decision-making processes through participatory urban planning frameworks (aligned with SDG 4.4.1 and SDG 8.6.1).

5.15 Water Resource Management

- **Flood and Waterbody Restoration:**
 - Retrofit stormwater systems to manage urban flooding effectively.
 - Preserve natural wetlands and rivers through blue corridors.
- **Centralized Wastewater Management:**
 - Upgrade sewage treatment plants to ensure clean water systems in cities.
- **Rainwater Harvesting:**
 - Promote rainwater collection systems for urban buildings to conserve water.
(Aligned with SDG 6.3.1 and SDG 6.6.1.)
- **Greywater Recycling:**
 - Reuse lightly used household water (e.g., from washing vegetables or bathing) for irrigation purposes after basic filtration.

5.16 Carbon Reduction

- **Energy Efficiency Policies:**
 - Introduce incentives for retrofitting buildings with energy-saving technologies.
- **Promote Renewable Energy:**
 - Integrate solar, wind, and waste-to-energy systems into urban infrastructure
(aligned with SDG 7.3.1 and SDG 13.2.1).

5.17 Community Engagement

- **Participatory Planning:**
 - Provide training for experts to enhance their role in urban planning.
 - Informing & training stakeholders.
 - Direct community participation in decision making.
 - Emphasizes local & bottom-up initiatives by forming advisory board for community input & supporting grassroots organization to push for inclusive urban policies.

5.18 Public Health Systems

- **Equitable Health Services:**
 - Ensure integrated health facilities in both urban-rural context and build climate-resilient health systems.
- **Disaster-Ready Urban Health Programs:**
 - Develop health programs with disaster preparedness to strengthen healthcare infrastructure.

5.19 Open Space Management

- **Multi-Use Open Spaces:**

- Retrofit open areas into parks, recreation zones, and urban forests for better urban livability.
- **Safe City Programs:**
 - Implement streetlights, surveillance, and smart policing for urban safety.
- **Innovative Open Space Design:**
 - Develop sports zones, and community centers for public use.
(Aligned with SDG 11.7.1 – Access to open spaces for all.)

5.20 Climate Change

Climate-Resilient Urban Policies

- **Green Infrastructure Development:**
 - Promote urban greening projects such as parks and vertical forests (from Malaysia).
 - Develop blue corridors for water body preservation and recreational sustainability (aligned with SDG 6.6.1).
- **Flood and Water Management:**
 - Strengthen flood defenses and adaptive land-use planning (from China).
 - Develop integrated watershed and stormwater management systems (aligned with SDG 13.2.1).
- **Low-Carbon Urban Development:**
 - Incentivize public transport, cycling, and energy-efficient technologies (Rwanda).
 - Encourage renewable energy adoption in urban areas, including solar and wind power systems.

Climate Adaptation and Disaster Resilience

Strategies for Resilience

- Integrate climate adaptation measures into urban development policies.
 - Implement zoning regulations to restrict construction in flood-prone areas.
 - Enforce building codes to ensure climate-resilient structures.
- Develop early warning systems for extreme weather events (China NUP).
- Enhance community disaster preparedness through public awareness and training programs (aligned with SDG 13.b).

6. Conclusion

The National Urbanization Policy for Bangladesh represents a pivotal milestone in the nation's journey toward sustainable and inclusive development. This comprehensive framework underscores the critical role of urbanization as a transformative force, capable of driving economic growth, fostering innovation, and enhancing the quality of life for all citizens. It acknowledges the diverse challenges posed by rapid urban expansion—such as environmental degradation, housing shortages, and social disparities—while leveraging these challenges as opportunities for progress and innovation.

Through this plan, Bangladesh aspires to create urban environments that balance economic dynamism with environmental stewardship, social equity, and cultural preservation. It emphasizes the importance of sustainable practices, climate resilience, and participatory governance in shaping cities that are adaptive to future demands and inclusive for all communities. The plan also seeks to bridge the urban-rural divide by fostering stronger linkages, ensuring that the benefits of urbanization extend beyond city boundaries to catalyze nationwide development.

As urbanization reshapes the socio-economic fabric of Bangladesh, this policy serves as a guiding beacon, encouraging stakeholders across all sectors to collaborate toward shared goals. By integrating global best practices with localized solutions, the plan envisions cities that are not only economic powerhouses but also havens of innovation, creativity, and cultural vibrancy.

Ultimately, the National Urbanization Policy invites every citizen, institution, and stakeholder to embrace a collective vision for a prosperous, resilient, and inclusive future—where cities are not just places to live, but engines of opportunity and symbols of national pride.